

A
S E R M O N

PREACHED AT
KENSINGTON CHURCH,

ON

JUNE the 29th, 1794

AFTER THE

VICTORY gained at SEA, JUNE the 1st.

BY THE

Rev. JOSEPH PHILLIMORE,

Late Gentleman Commoner of *Christ Church*, OXON.

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK A SERMON
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A SERMON

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A SERMON.

MATH. viii. 25.

And his Disciples came unto him; and awoke him, saying, Lord, save us, we perish.

IN a chapter previous to that from whence my text is taken, our blessed Saviour, had been preaching his most excellent sermon on the mount to his disciples, wherein he had diffused comfort and consolation, adding thereunto satisfaction to the whole human race, and after having pointed out his doctrine in a very specific manner, the many and various duties, of a good christian; exhorting all to follow minutely the good advice contained in his discourse, charging them not only to be hearers of the gospel, but doers also, intimating therein, that it availeth little, to listen and hearken, to whatever religion, and virtue, instruct, direct, and authorize mankind to do, provided the greater and more important part, is omitted, which our blessed Redeemer, during the whole time while he was on earth, was unwearied in well doing, and particularly exhorting all those who wished to follow him, to imitate continually, and that was the practical part of religion; let us not be faint hearted, nor profess with our lips, and utter with our tongue, what our heart knows we are not able to perform; let us shew forth God's praises and thanksgivings, that by being attentive hearers, and having received the fruits of good works go forth with joy and publish the glad tidings of Salvation, for unto us is born a son the Saviour of the world. For every one of you shall be known by your fruits, for every good tree bringeth forth good fruit, but an evil tree bringeth forth evil and corrupted fruit, and is hewn down and cast into the fire, and as the tree is more valuable that bringeth forth good fruit to its earthly possessor, so much greater value, shall those men be of to their heavenly father, who from their first entrance into life have delighted in good works and actions, how much more shall

they be rewarded in a future state of bliss, than those, whose evil deeds have multiplied their sorrows and sins here, and worn out their constitution.

This chapter hath been reckoned by some worthy and good christians, as the miraculous scripture, having contained in it, the most wonderful acts of clemency and mercy, the greatest display of divine love and tenderness that could possibly be possessed, and as such I have chosen my text, as our blessed Lord and Master, found it necessary to exhibit wonders and perform miracles as you may all observe in this place, rather than so many souls should be lost, let me compare the present situation of sinful men, in these our more improved and enlightened days, that although, the greatest: rewards and punishments, are held out to mankind, the former as an incitement and encouragement and exhortation to every good work, and the latter as a terror to every evil and wicked one; yet the wicked must cry out and say, Lord, save us, we perish, remembering the blessed Jesus, hath born all our infirmities, yet we have a resting place, a rock of defence, in time of trouble to flee unto, we are not as our blessed Saviour described he was, when he said unto his disciples, the foxes have holes, and the birds of the air have nests, but the son of man hath not where to lay his head. I will add a few observations on our blessed Saviour's manner of teaching, before I shew the great necessity of all sinners, becoming truly penitent, lest they perish, and that is first, his manner was grave and serious, pious and ardent, plain and profitable; brevity without obscureness, gravity without affectation, eloquence without meretricious ornament, such was the great power and influence of Christ's doctrine, that it made all that heard him admirers and believers, and caused great astonishment in their minds and reformation in their manners and had every reason to confirm these words of scripture, we verily believe him to be the son of God, for never knew we any spake, and act, as he hath done; and it came to pass, when Jesus had ended these sayings, the people were astonished at his doctrine, for he taught them as one having authority; his authority was the best, his religion was the purest, it breathed forth charity and love, his love, was visibly displayed to the whole human race, that their souls might be saved, his charity was exhibited in covering a multitude of sins, and healing all the infirmities human nature endures; even the leper was cleansed of his spots, the paralytic received strength, who had been grievously tormented, and

Peter's mother in law had been cured of a fever on a sudden, which miracles are particularly described in a preceding chapter.

The more we search the scriptures the better able we shall be to judge of the frailty and weakness of human nature, and to make such observations, as will convince all mankind, at least the most religious and virtuous part, that during our short and transitory passage in these earthly regions, where there is a great mixture of good and evil, that very often unexpected storms, and tempests arise and we are surrounded with turbulent and violent appearances of approaching misfortunes, and insurmountable troubles, and may compare the present situation to the mariner, who for a series of years must go through the threatening and dangerous scenes of chance, either of good, or bad fortune, and be subjected to be tossed in the troubled ocean, now and then beholding it serene and calm, and very frequently becomes a witness of many distressed objects, shipwrecked, forlorn and apparently cast away, neglected and deserted, yet as he knows very well, long ere he sets out on his prosperous and advantageous voyage, he must place all his dependance on divine providence that he may escape and avoid all the dangers, the restless and disturbed deep may expose him unto during his passage, yet at the last, through the mercy of God, he may arrive at the wished for haven, where plenty and security will protect him for his trouble, and the service he has been of to his country by returning with those necessary supplies, for his fellow creatures, he left behind, and without which the mercantile part of this creation would neither be rich or opulent in the latter part of their lives; such, is the great desire of gain, and power, and authority, that we behold many risque and venture their lives, some after a few years absence ruin their constitutions, returning with opulence, spend it in extravagance, indulging themselves in idleness and passing their days in inactivity and lasciviousness. Others who have been led to search unknown countries, and visit foreign regions for the sake of information and improvement, and have quitted their native place for the sake of the propagation of the gospel, and encouraging virtue and religion, God grant, they may receive the honour due unto them, and when they return, receive a sufficient recompence for their rewards; all such examples as these, those who have not had inclination, nor have been forced to leave their domestic happiness, and wonted societies of their youth and innocence, owe many great and valuable comforts unto, such is the mixture, such is the

composition of frail man, unbounded are his desires, various are his expectations, some are promoted to honour, some born to dishonour; yet in every birth, in every climate, and situation of life, more or less man is exposed to different trials, some accidental, some troubles, are to be expected long ere they happen, but then we have this consolation, as we see the fatal and evil day approaching, we have every opportunity, to prepare for the attack, and place our reliance and dependance alone on the Almighty, and as the storm was sudden, and unexpected, and terrified the disciples of the blessed Jesus, that even, the sea began to roar, and the whole ocean looked black, and the wind to sound terribly, and the foaming billows, and boisterous waves rolled in upon them, so that they verily thought they should perish, instantly as their faith urged them to call on their all-powerful master, he listened unto their cry of justice, and stilled and rebuked the troubled waves, and all was calm and quiet.

Let me now rouse all mankind, and particularly sinners to have a lively faith in God, that they may have a due sense of his great mercies, that as they have been carried along for a series of years, and length of days, in the deceitful and fallacious path of pleasure and dissipation, they are still supported and borne up by a very feeble and slippery, and tender prop, and if not seriously and instantly consider their dreadful situation, may die in their sins, and cry out too late in the greatest misery and the bitter pangs and agonies of severe and conquering death, Lord, save us, we perish. Sinners delight in laying snares for the innocent and virtuous, and encourage and invite many a thoughtless and giddy youth, by the wages of sin, that all the ways of Satan are pleasing, amiable, and enviable, and prosperous, but they are deceitful on the weights; they are lighter than vanity itself, they are full of ungodliness and wrong, and will haunt the wicked person even in his latter days, to overthrow him. Prosperity in worldly affairs, often makes a man think that he shall never know adversity, and while he is supported by art and flattery, believes it; but this is not a life consisting entirely in prosperity. Man is a composition of good and evil, and in order to escape adversity and enjoy prosperity, he must suffer the one with patience and resignation in the early part of his life, and as he advance forward, he shall bear it patiently, and supported by hope, on his future expectation, shall be rewarded with prosperity, clothed and adorned with that simple and never

fading dress and attire of virtue and chastity, subduing and conquering the gaudy and presumptuous attacks of vice, arrogance and pride.

This is the state of mortal man here below, yet within him dwelleth an immortal soul, that points out an hereafter unto him and if not very attentively modelled and particular care paid to him, when reason first enters his tender mind, in all probability his irregular and unruly passions being numerous will get the better of him, and the inconsiderate actions of his younger days will bring his grey hairs with grief and sorrow to the grave, the end of that journey from whence no traveller ever returns. Many there are at this present time perhaps among us, who are living in the deceitful scenes of sin and wickedness, and running where they would be very sorry to be told, a very swift, and sure race of destruction and ruin, despising what the aged aged parent or faithful and experienced friend and companion, hath often admonished, never as yet having felt the timely correction of God, by sickness or adversity, but day after day rolling on, and continually seeking the societies of the profligate, the abandoned, and the wicked. Man it is allowed, and its true, is formed for societies, for intercourse, but for such as either improve, or inform, the mind and understanding; he was made and brought into the world of such noble and glorious materials, having the image of his maker in an inferior degree, to pass his whole time in feasting and idle talking, spending the beginning of the day in ludicrous and unprofitable company and the latter in crimes of excessive intemperance, excessive indelicacies and irregularities: such my younger part of this congregation, is too much the fashion and the custom, and the practice of the present time, yet it is to be hoped the young will stop their career and race, and have a due sense of God's love and affection, and call upon him in the time of trouble and need, and at a time when he may be heard, and that is right instantly, for he has declared he is ever ready to listen and even willing to pardon and receive the returning and penitent sinner. May you all escape divine wrath and vengeance and punishment, beholding with your eyes, and being fully convinced in your hearts, of the numbers that are likely to perish, yet may be spared, if they will but imitate the blessed example of our Saviour's faithful disciples in my text, who being warned of their danger, cried out in time, Lord save us, we perish: may sincere repentance work out your own salvation, may you all have that timely notice, that not one of you may perish: may the prodigal if there is

any one among you be convinced of his error of life, and with firm resolution of amendment return to his afflicted and forgiving father: may the adulterer miss no opportunity of bewailing his past sins, which are of the highest degree, implore for pardon and forgiveness: may you all individually receive that impression in your hearts and minds, that early repentance will get the dominion and conquer sin: and that you may all be serene and calm when the awful and melancholy hour of dissolution waiteth on you, and when the secrets of all hearts shall be opened and disclosed, which to the young on the pursuit of diversion and pleasure, may seem at a great distance; yet man that is born of a woman hath but a short time to live, and so fast, so fleet is the wing of time, that we are all soon brought to the same dust from whence we are sprung, and as the fond father in the fulness of his inexpressible joy, received his long absent son into his melting arms, may we be received by that tender and merciful father, who wishes, not even one of his children to be lost, but all to be saved. May we be worthy of his embraces who knows no bounds to pardon and forgiveness: may God of his infinite mercy and wisdom inspire you all, with such reflections on the great danger and perils of a sinful life, that you may all arise and awake from the soporific and dark regions of sin and woe, to a godly and virtuous life, that by the assistance of the divine will, all mankind may shun and escape sleeping in eternal and everlasting death, where sorrow and misery continually inhabit.

To conclude. Let me exhort all this congregation to consider the great value, and the inestimable blessings planted in our hearts of gratitude, praise, and thanksgivings, and as God is entitled to it from every christian heart, for every benefit man receives in private as well as in public, let no one be deficient in this important duty, and according to the advantage received, so great, as far as frail man is able to perform, return it with gratitude in the best manner he is able.

Let me prevail on you to consider devoutly, for I am fully convinced you cannot help continually thinking on the great, and signal mercies, so recently poured down upon us, in such a miraculous manner, for let us be ever so powerful, ever so skilful in any art or science, vain is the help of man, if the Lord will not fight for us, and with us; and as it hath pleased the Almighty to give us victory in the day of battle, shall we be silent, or wanting as a nation, in every church, or house of prayer, where public

praise and thanksgiving are to be paid, not to express our gratitude, and shew forth our praises not only with our lips but in our hearts; shall we not say, Lord thou hast spared us from ruin and destruction, thou hast given victory to our fleet, and saved us from falling a captive prey: prepare our hearts and minds with a due sense of thy power, and inspire us with such a great degree of humility, not to presume we have gained the most compleat and naval victory ever obtained by any nation? but on the contrary, that it was thy will, that we should by thy aid and assistance, conquer an insulting and wicked enemy, and make him fearful of continuing in the practice of what is hateful to thee, and destructive to mankind. Out of the deep, O Lord, have we cried unto thee, and thou hast heard us, many hast thou spared, and many hast thou taken unto thee; yet scripture comforts every christian in the greatest sorrow and affliction; blessed are they that die in the Lord, they shall be eased from their labour, therefore we may conclude, those glorious and courageous heroes who have fallen into the deep in so memorable and virtuous a cause, they will receive a crown of glory, and their former sins thou wilt forgive, and receive them unto thee, for thou hast succoured us.

This and every day is the day, in which we ought to give thanks, this is the place, and in every place we ought particularly to commemorate God's mercies, but this most particularly, for here we ought not to have come, without intending to perform acts of religious worship, and as we are assembled in God's holy sanctuary, let us offer our most solemn prayers individually, in heart and voice, confessing without him, nothing is strong, nothing is holy; unto Almighty God, therefore let us, and the whole nation, give as our bounden duty, praise and thanksgivings; that it hath pleased our gracious father to stretch forth his arm and protect our fleet, and scattered our proud and insulting enemies, in the imagination of their hearts. This is becoming every good christian, every disciple of the Lord, every virtuous nation, every regular society, every christian parish, where virtue and religion are particularly professed, and as I hope we are such, and have been as fortunate as the disciples mentioned in my text: have cried out in good time, Lord, save us, we perish; now therefore depart with these words of the Royal Psalmist, not unto us, O Lord, not unto us, but unto thy name give the praise, for thy loving mercy and salvation's sake. Happy are the people that

are in such a case, yea blessed are the people who have the Lord for their God. Now to God, &c. &c.

FINIS.

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